radar followed the American nuclear armed bombers as they approached the borders of the Soviet bloc before making an abrupt turn over the Adriatic Sea. They repeated that maneuver again and again. It is not exactly clear when the news was delivered to Khrushchev (it was either October 25 or 26) but there is no doubt that he got the message. The Soviet deputy foreign minister, Vasilii Kuznetsov, confided a few weeks later to one of his junior colleagues that after receiving the information about SAC going to the highest prewar level of DEFCON, Nikita Khrushchev "shat his pants."[16]

While some of Kennedy's advisers believed that raising the DEFCON level was useful, as it might deter the Soviets from taking action against US targets in Europe, the news helped convince Khrushchev that the Americans were getting ready not just to attack Cuba but also to hit Moscow. He concluded that the letter he had wanted to send via Bolshakov the previous day would make things even worse. Leonid Brezhnev remembered how in a panic, Khrushchev recalled the telegram he had already ordered to be sent to Kennedy. Instead, he called a Presidium meeting to present his colleagues with a very different agenda. Khrushchev was sounding a retreat.[17]

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"THE AMERICANS SAY THAT THE SOVIET INSTALLATIONS IN Cuba must be dismantled," he told the gathering. If they were expecting an emotional outburst full of expletives, they were in for a surprise. "Perhaps that should be done: it's not capitulation on our part because, if we shoot, they'll shoot back," said Khrushchev, surprising his colleagues. "The Americans have taken fright—no doubt about that, evidently," he declared, projecting his own state of panic onto his American counterpart. He continued: "Kennedy slept with a wooden knife." When the bewildered Mikoyan asked what that might mean, Khrushchev explained that according to a popular saying, those who go to hunt bear for the first time take along a wooden knife to clean their trousers.

He then presented his policy toward Cuba as a victory rather than a defeat. "We have now made Cuba a focus of world attention; we have